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Culture (OWC): [Zulu \(FX20\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: No Date

Coverage Date: Ca.1800-1890s

Place Coverage: South Africa

Section Title(S): WOMEN IN STATE INSTITUTIONS

This emphasis on the physical isolation of the *umNdlunkulu* was important not only for its effect upon the living conditions of the women themselves, but also for its impact on the way they were viewed by society. *UmNdlunkulu* became almost mythically untouchable, and whole pages of traditions are devoted to warnings about the ill-fate of the 'more amorous' who tried to cross the *isiGodlo* wall.⁵⁵ There were rumors, usually made by those who had never been inside the *isiGodlo*, that *umNdlunkulu* went around completely naked, a comment usually made about female diviners,⁵⁶ and suggesting that *umNdlunkulu's* association with the king was analogous to the diviner's connection with the spirit world. In essence, then, although they were neither wives nor mothers, neither diviners nor sorceresses, *umNdlunkulu* were just as liminal and powerful from the perspective of the average Zulu male. But their structural liminality was not based on a proximity to the spirit world as manifested through birth, death or the foreign lineage; rather, it was based on their proximity to the power and prestige of the king.

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While the picture of these women, locked away in the *isiGodlo* and regimented sexually, implies a lack of power, *umNdlunkulu* actually enjoyed increased status, *vis-à-vis* other women and 'common' men, commensurate with their marginality and danger. Ngubane has pointed out that pollution, the form of liminality associated with most women, can signify either a surplus of spiritual power, in the case of diviners, or a deficiency, in the case of mothers and mourners. There can be little doubt that the 'other' world with which *umNdlunkulu* were associated, that is the world of the king, was one of great power in Zulu society. The status of the enclosure's residents reflected this fact. *UmNdlunkulu* could verbally harass and taunt men to an extent usually permitted to most women only during their *omula* puberty ceremony, and powerful men who were allowed verbally to assault most women were forced to demur in regard to *umNdlunkulu*.⁵⁷ They were important critics of the

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actions of men, singing either to praise or, more often, to condemn the acts of soldiers in battle.⁵⁸ But perhaps the most important sign of their status was that after the king married them off, they outranked all other wives in the homestead irrespective of the order in which they were married or of the prestige of other wives' lineages.⁵⁹

The development of a centralized state, which usurped the powers of lineages and homesteads, had a profound effect upon the way some women related to the rest of society. Yet, although the new source of certain women's structural liminality shifted the foundation of their power away from their individual social and biological roles into the domain of male relationships, these women did not necessarily suffer a loss of personal power or status. Rather, it can be argued that being associated with the king, who was a less ambiguous source of liminality, *umNdlunkulu* experienced an increase in status and power as a result of Shaka's reforms.

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⁵⁵ Bryant, *Olden Times*, 637–41.

⁵⁶ Webb and Wright, *Stuart Archive*, ii, 91.

⁵⁷ *Ibid.* ii, 251, 179; iv, 78; Krige, 'Girls' puberty songs', 176–7.

⁵⁸ Webb and Wright, *Stuart Archive*, ii, 170.

⁵⁹ *Ibid.* i, 337–8.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



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